

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

This work is an adaptation of Tyndale Open Study Notes © 2023 Tyndale House Publishers, licensed under the CC BY-SA 4.0 license. The adaptation, Aquifer Open Study Notes, was created by Mission Mutual and is also licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0.

This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

2 Kings

2 Kings

The book of 2 Kings tells about many leaders who did not learn from the mistakes of those who came before them. Because they turned away from God, these kings brought judgment on themselves and their nation. At the same time, the book includes inspiring examples of people who honored God and obeyed his word. They experienced the blessings God had promised. As we learn about the lives of these kings and leaders, we can learn to avoid their mistakes and enjoy the blessings God gives to those who love and serve him.

Setting

The book of 2 Kings continues the story of the divided kingdoms of Israel and Judah. It begins where 1 Kings ends, with Ahaziah ruling the northern kingdom of Israel and Jehoshaphat ruling the southern kingdom of Judah. The book follows the history of both kingdoms until they came to an end. The northern kingdom fell in 722 BC, and the southern kingdom fell in 586 BC.

Summary

The book of 2 Kings is organized around the reigns of the kings of Israel and Judah. It covers four main periods:

1. the final years of the northern kingdom's third family line of kings (853–841 BC, 1:1–9:37),
2. the time of the northern kingdom's fourth family line of kings (841–752 BC, 10:1–15:12),
3. the decline and fall of the northern kingdom (752–722 BC, 15:13–17:41), and
4. the final years of the southern kingdom (722–586 BC, 18:1–25:30).

The book begins with the death of King Ahaziah of Israel after an accident (1:1–18). It also records the end of Elijah's earthly ministry, when God took him up to heaven (2:1–12). Elijah's role as prophet then passed to Elisha. The next several chapters focus on Elisha's miracles and his guidance to kings and others (2:12–8:15; see 9:1–10).

The reigns of Jehoram and Ahaziah, kings of Judah, bring the story to the important year of 841 BC (8:16–29). In that year, Jehu killed Joram, king of Israel, and Ahaziah, king of Judah. He also put Jezebel to death, killed the remaining members of Ahab's family, and executed the officials who worshiped Baal, a false god worshiped by many people in the region (9:11–10:29).

After these events, Jehu began his 28-year reign as king of Israel (10:30–36). Around the same time, Athaliah seized the throne of Judah and ruled for six years (11:1–20). Her reign ended when supporters of David's royal line made the young Joash king (12:1–21).

For a time, the kingdoms of Israel and Judah enjoyed peace and success (14:23–15:7). However, the northern kingdom of Israel continued to turn away from God and began to decline. After the assassination of King Zechariah (15:8–12), a series of kings ruled for short periods: Shallum, Menahem, Pekahiah, Pekah, and Hoshea (15:13–17:2).

Hoshea was the last king of Israel and ruled from 732 to 722 BC. He placed his trust in Egypt and rebelled against Assyria. As a result, Assyria captured Samaria, the capital of Israel, and the northern kingdom came to an end in 722 BC (17:3–6). The author then explains why Israel fell and describes how Samaria was settled by new groups of people after its capture (17:7–41).

The final section of 2 Kings (18:1–25:30) focuses on the history of Judah. King Hezekiah is remembered for trusting the Lord during a time of great pressure (18:5–6; see 18:13–20:11). King Josiah is praised for his commitment to obeying the law of the Lord (23:19; see 22:8–23:25).

Even so, both kings made serious mistakes. Hezekiah showed the treasures of his kingdom to Babylon's envoys (20:12–19). Josiah died after going into battle against Pharaoh Neco of Egypt (23:29–30; see 2 Chronicles 35:20–25).

After Josiah's death, the last kings of Judah continued to do what was evil in the Lord's sight. As a result, the kingdom suffered greatly and was eventually destroyed by King Nebuchadnezzar II of Babylon (2 Kings 23:31–25:21). God's promised judgment came upon Judah, just as the prophets had warned (see Jeremiah 38:17–23). The kingdom that had once been strong and prosperous came to an end.

The book of 2 Kings ends with two final accounts. The first describes events in Judah after the fall of Jerusalem (2 Kings 25:22–26). The second tells how Jehoiachin was later released from prison in Babylon (25:27–30).

Author and Date

The book of 2 Kings continues the story begun in 1 Kings and was likely written by the same author, although his identity is unknown. The author had access to historical sources that helped him write a detailed account of the divided kingdoms of Israel and Judah. He also understood that the success or failure

of the people depended on whether they obeyed the Mosaic covenant (God's agreement with Israel through Moses).

The author's detailed knowledge of Judah's later history suggests that he may have lived in or near Jerusalem. He may even have witnessed some of the events that led to the city's fall. It is not clear whether he was still alive when the final section about Jehoiachin's release in Babylon was written (561 BC; 25:25–30). If not, these verses may have been added by another writer who shared the same viewpoint and purpose.

One Jewish tradition says that the prophet Jeremiah wrote both 1 and 2 Kings. According to this tradition, he was taken to Babylon after Nebuchadnezzar returned from a military campaign in Egypt around 568 BC. It also says that Jeremiah lived into his nineties while in Babylon.

The final version of 2 Kings was probably written soon after Jerusalem fell in 586 BC. The last section was probably added shortly after Nebuchadnezzar II died in 562 BC.

Timeline

Second Kings contains many details about when the kings of Israel and Judah ruled. However, these details by themselves do not provide exact dates in the modern calendar. Scholars determine these dates by comparing Israel's records with records from neighboring nations, such as Assyria, Babylon, and Egypt, and with astronomical data.

These different sources agree closely with one another. This agreement provides strong evidence that the historical accounts in 2 Kings are reliable and carefully recorded.

Meaning and Message

Each king of the divided kingdoms was judged by whether he remained faithful to God. The author evaluates every king using one of two descriptions: he either "did what pleased the Lord" or "did what was evil in the Lord's sight."

The kings of Israel consistently turned away from God. They followed the example of Jeroboam son of Nebat, who led Israel into sin (13:2, 11; 14:24; 15:9; 17:2). Many of the kings of Judah are also criticized for their unfaithfulness to God (see for example, 8:18).

Manasseh is especially condemned because of his widespread idolatry (the worship of false gods) and apostasy (turning away from God; see 21:2–9). Several

kings who ruled after him followed his example (23:32, 37; 24:9, 19).

Several kings of Judah are praised because they did what was pleasing in the Lord's sight (12:2; 14:3; 15:3, 34; 18:3; 22:2). These kings cared for the maintenance and repair of the temple (12:6–16; 22:3–7). They also sought to obey God's word and encourage others to do the same (18:6; 22:8–13; 23:1–3).

Two kings receive special praise. Hezekiah is commended for trusting in the Lord and obeying God's word (18:5–6). Josiah is praised for his commitment to the law of Moses (23:25). The message is clear. God's people should live according to the teachings of God's word and seek to do what is pleasing in his sight (compare Psalm 119:9–11, 111; 2 Timothy 3:16–17).

The attention given to the final days of the prophet Elijah (1:3–17; 2:1–11) and to Elisha's powerful ministry (2:12–25; 3:11–19; 4:1–7:2; 8:1–2) emphasizes the importance of sharing God's message with others. Through this message, people can come to know the Lord and enter into a covenant relationship (a binding relationship) with him (Acts 20:18–21; 2 Timothy 2:15; 4:2; 2 Corinthians 3:4–6).

Finally, the failures of even the faithful kings remind God's people to remain faithful to the Lord and continue serving him. As they do, they can experience God's blessings in their lives (Psalm 84:11; Romans 14:7–8). They should also remember that they will one day stand before God for judgment (Romans 14:10–11; 2 Corinthians 5:10). On that day, God will reward and commend those who have remained faithful to him (2 Timothy 4:7–8; Revelation 2:10; see Matthew 25:23).